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ELECTION 2026 COOK COUNTY BOARD PRESIDENT

For Preckwinkle, eyes on future

Poised to win fifth term, Democratic incumbent focuses on budget challenges, finding successor

By A.D. Quig
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

During her 2018 campaign, Toni Preckwinkle said her third term as Cook County Board president would be her last. She's now on the verge of winning her fifth.

Preckwinkle, 79, faces only token opposition Nov. 3 from Libertarian Michael Murphy after trouncing downtown Ald. Brendan Reilly, her well-funded challenger, 69% to 31% in the March Democratic primary. If she serves another full four-year term, she will have led the county for two decades, second only to George Dunne, who held the job from 1969 to 1990.

She has worn the long tenure lightly. Asked at a recent news conference how she felt about the upcoming election, Preckwinkle gave a small chuckle. "I'm actually on the ballot," she said, as if it were an afterthought. Asked why she is running again after saying she would quit after her third term, Preckwinkle told the Tribune, "The pandemic (in 2020 and 2021) kind of upended things."

"Government at all levels continues to feel the impact of the pandemic and the economic catastrophe that followed. I'm hopeful that we'll have gotten through that almost entirely by the time we're at the end of this term and on a much better footing, both financially and in terms of how people feel about the world," she said.

Preckwinkle told fellow Democrats in August 2025 she intends to serve her entire term, and previously said even if she wasn't in

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AMERICA'S HAIRYLAND

Across the border in Wisconsin, a werewolf legend refuses to die

By Christopher Borrelli
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

ELKHORN, Wis. — Bray Road runs for 3 miles through Elkhorn, Wisconsin. At the south, it begins not far from Lake Geneva. Enter off U.S. Route 12, curl east, and other than a slight jog, it's pretty much a straight shot to State Route 11. Hence all the snaking peel-out marks left by amateur racers. Foliage rustles in the autumn wind here, and where there aren't corn husks swaying, there are flat, lonely expanses of dirt where crops have been harvested.

As Midwestern scenes go, there's nothing remarkable about Bray Road.

Other than the werewolf that has stalked it for nearly a century.

Chicago has long boasted of its paranormal residents. Humanoid moths and demon babies, hitchhiking ghouls, the occasional sea monster and even a suspicious phantom kangaroo or two. But southeastern Wisconsin — specifically that cluster of rural communities along the Illinois line — has harbored the Beast of Bray Road since 1936.

Other than a handful of recurring characteristics — pointy ears, long muzzle, sharp claws, hunched back, curiously inverted hind legs and a preference for walking on two feet — sightings of this abomination are, at best, inconsistent: Some say it is precisely 5 feet, 8 inches tall, and some say it is closer to 7 feet tall. Some claim its yellow eyes burn with fathomless evil, and some say it just tends to look annoyed in passing headlights. When it's not

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Jace Mann, 11, lets out a scream in the beast howl competition at Beast Fest in Elkhorn, Wisconsin, on Saturday. The Beast of Bray Road is part of local folklore, with the wolf-like creature allegedly first seen in the area in 1936. **CHRIS SWEDA/TRIBUNE**

TRICKS, NO TREATS: Halloween candy sales are off to a slow start this year, down more than 6% from this time last year, as U.S. consumers grapple with high living costs and eye-popping chocolate prices. **Business, Page B2**

68 dead in Spain railroad collision

Another high-speed crash has operators searching for fixes

By Joseph Wilson and Alicia León
ASSOCIATED PRESS

URDA, Spain — A high-speed train slammed into another that had stopped on the tracks in Spain on Wednesday, killing at least 68 people and injuring dozens in the second deadly rail collision this year.

The regional government of Castilla La Mancha confirmed the death toll and said another 58 people were receiving medical treatment at hospitals. Rescue workers searched the wreckage through the day for survivors and bodies.

The collision came just nine months after another deadly crash involving high-speed trains operated by the same two companies in southern Spain in January.

"Today all of Spain is grieving," Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez said from the crash site, where he announced that his government would declare three days of national mourning.

Sánchez called for increased safety measures to restore confidence in a high-speed rail system that was once a source of national pride.

"It is unacceptable for a country like Spain to suffer two high-speed rail accidents in the same year," said Sánchez, who faces a national election Nov. 29.

Spain's rail system operator, ADIF, said the crash occurred Wednesday morning in the central province of Toledo, involving two high-speed trains carrying hundreds of passengers and heading south from Madrid to Seville.

A train operated by the state-owned RENFE company struck the rear of another train

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INSIDE

Gunshot detection tool faces scrutiny

Interim Chicago police Superintendent Fred Waller acknowledged Wednesday a gunshot detection pilot may launch across a third of the city in as little as a week. But as aldermen pressed for answers about which company will provide the technology and how it will operate, the top cop had little to say. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

MENDOZA'S PITCH: Chicago businesses would "stop feeling like piggy banks" if she's mayor, candidate contends. **Page A5**

'Every time I visit Broadview, I encounter Jesus'

Chicago clergy meet with pope to advocate for immigrants detained in suburban ICE facility

By Rebecca Johnson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Thousands from all over the world surrounded Jeanne Rattenbury as she prepared to watch Pope Leo XIV speak Wednesday at St. Peter's Square in Vatican City.

As she listened to messages in Arabic and Chinese, among other languages, she felt strongly that faith was connecting people from all walks of life. What she called the "universal church" perhaps lent more meaning to what she was about to do.

Rattenbury was one of about 30 Chicago-area clergy, religious leaders and laypeople who met Leo briefly at the weekly general audience to further advocate for immigrants detained in the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement processing center in Broadview.

The Coalition for Spiritual and Public Leadership provides pastoral care to those in the west suburban facility, which grew in

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Pope Leo XIV greets members of the Coalition for Spiritual and Public Leadership on Wednesday at the Vatican. **VATICAN MEDIA**

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